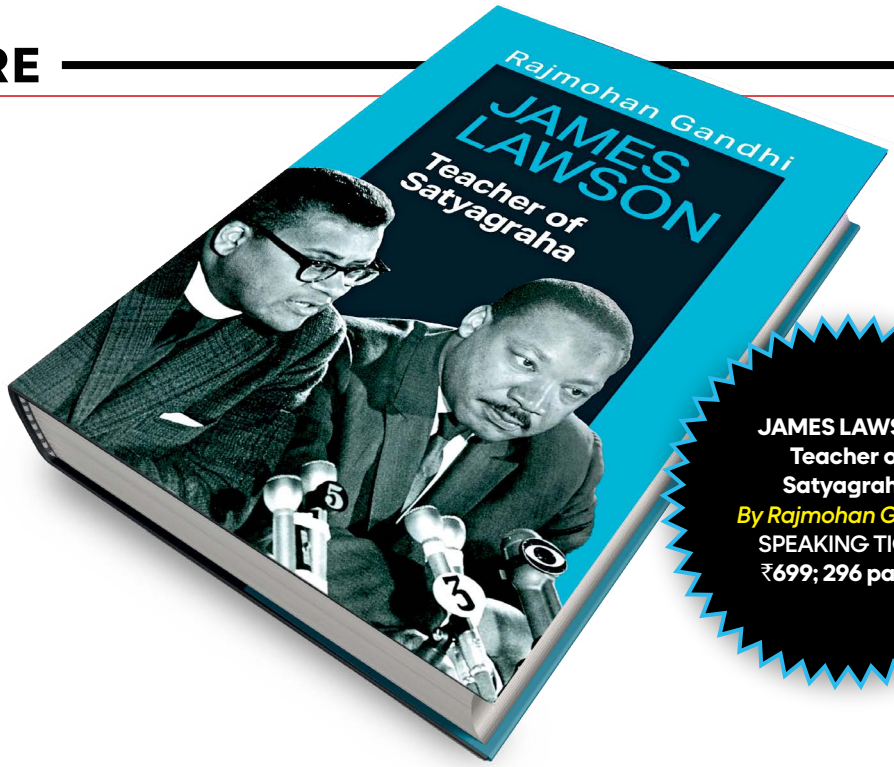


JAMES LAWSON
Teacher of Satyagraha
By Rajmohan Gandhi
SPEAKING TIGER
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In 1936, Mahatma Gandhi and his long-time secretary Mahavir Desai were living in an ashram in Bardoli, Gujarat, when they were visited by an African-American delegation led by theologian-philosopher Howard Thurman. A wide-ranging three-hour conversation ensued, and Gandhi came away impressed by the power of the African-American struggle for their rights, especially their application of non-violent methods of protest, similar to the satyagrahas spearheaded by Gandhi in India. Over a decade later, in the 1950s, Desai's account of the meeting in the book, *Nonviolence in Peace and War* (1942), was read by a young African-American activist called James Lawson (1928-2024) while he was living in Nagpur as a Methodist missionary.

Lawson went on to become one of the leading tacticians and ideologues of the American Civil Rights Movement, working directly alongside Martin Luther King Jr, who was similarly impressed with Gandhian philosophy. The life story of this remarkable man is told with wit, compassion and academic rigour in *James Lawson: Teacher of Satyagraha*, by the historian and professor Rajmohan Gandhi (who also happens to be the Mahatma's grandson). "That meeting and Desai's account of it obviously made a big impact on Lawson," the 91-year-old Gandhi recalls. "Also, from the beginning, Lawson was very clear about his own, non-dogmatic version of Christianity, and he wasn't interested in converting everybody he came across. I think this made it easier for him to dive deep into Gandhi's ideology, and he was more receptive to the philosophy of satyagraha. When I met Lawson in 2024, he told me that he had procured Mahavir Desai's book in 1942, and that it was still sitting on his shelf over 80 years later."

GANDHI SHOWS US HOW LAWSON APPLIED THE LESSONS OF SATYAGRAHA TO THE NASHVILLE STUDENT MOVEMENT, CULMINATING IN THE FAMOUS NASHVILLE SIT-INS OF 1960

In the book, Gandhi provides a detailed account of Lawson's three-year stint in Nagpur from 1953–56, complemented by extracts from letters Lawson wrote during his time in India. More importantly, Gandhi shows us how Lawson ended up applying the lessons of satyagraha to the Nashville Student Movement, culminating in the famous Nashville sit-ins of 1960. The sit-ins protested racial segregation at lunch counters, and were marked by disciplined, principled non-violence. They gained a lot of traction in the American and global media, and the non-violent nature of the sit-ins made it easier for global observers to condemn the unabashed bigotry of white Americans. Gandhi is also quick to point out that Lawson and others in the Civil Rights Movement were just as quick to raise their voices against the oppression of women or queer people.

"I don't wish to point fingers," says Gandhi. "I don't want to say that 'Oh, these are the areas in which contemporary socio-political movements are lacking'. But I do urge my own students and everybody else to study the interconnected nature of the causes that Lawson took up, for example. Yes, he is primarily known for his struggle to get equal rights for African-Americans. But he also